Asia is being shaped largely by the outlook of the US, the power of China, the weight of Russia, the collectivism of ASEAN, the volatility of the Middle East and the rise of India. If there is an underplayed element, that is in the presence of Japan. The strategic withdrawal of Japan along with the Partition of India skewed the power balance in the Asian continent. The West may be responsible for both developments, but is now recalculating in its own interest.

There are two imponderables which could create a very different scenario in Asia. One is the future posture of Japan, bringing back into the strategic calculus a major economy with enormous technological capabilities. The second is the fluidity in the Korean Peninsula, one that could overturn longstanding assumptions. Both were earlier impacted by the rising power of China. But now, they could also respond to a new American posture. For India, the first will have direct consequences, but even the second would not be irrelevant. Between them, we could well see influences from East Asia that go beyond those of China.

The issue is not just of power calculations but equally of mindsets. Neither India nor Japan had historically focused on each other when it came to addressing their respective security situations. Yet, they both think similarly on the big issues of the day, especially in the last few years. This applies to power shifts as much as power deficits. So, what strategy may not have consciously generated, the vagaries of an uncertain world may well have done. A shared interest in securing the global commons and to contributing to global goods has brought about a convergence between very different polities. This realization in two nations that they have little choice but to help shape their continent is now an impelling force of a new relationship.

In the forgotten footnotes of history are conversations between Japanese and British diplomats in 1904-05 exploring military cooperation against a Russian threat. Some British hoped that it could lead to the dispatch of Japanese troops to India. That prospect of such an army commitment in return for British naval support never materialized since Japan decisively defeated the Russians at sea in Tsushima. But what did not happen does illustrate a working principle of international relations. As two imperial powers that were proximate to the expanding Russian empire, the UK and